

to the military, women wielded economic power; they had authority over the household, and could own, inherit, and transfer wealth.

Athenian women

Ancient Greece was famed for its democracy, but Athenian women did not have the same citizenship rights as their male counterparts. They were denied the opportunity to vote or participate in politics. Many women's daily lives were confined to running the household, spinning and weaving cloth, and producing children. They also had numerous religious functions, and many women had jobs outside the home. Women did not receive formal education, although wealthy women may have had the privilege of being taught how to read and write. The wealthy could also leave everyday tasks to slaves, brought to Greece as a



▲ Funerary art

This lekythos, or oil vessel, contained oil that would be applied to a woman's skin during funeral rites, if she died without marrying.

IN BRIEF

GREEK ANTIQUITY

There was no single universal experience for women across the city states of ancient Greece, but religion and warfare loomed large in many of their lives.

800 BCE

• **8th century** The Delphic oracle is established.

• **776** The Heraean Games, the first official Panhellenic female athletic competition, is held in the stadium at Olympia.

700 BCE

• **c. 630-612** Sappho of Lesbos, one of the earliest Greek lyric poets, is born; she dies c. 570.

500 BCE

• **450** Athenian funerary monuments begin to depict women; the legal code of Gortyn, Crete, is inscribed on city walls, containing many laws pertaining to women—such as their right to some property in the case of divorce.

• **441** Sophocles premieres his play *Antigone* (about a young woman who stands up to the power of the state) at the City Dionysia festival.

• **430-420** The Adonia festival is celebrated annually by women to mourn the death of Adonis, the mortal lover of the goddess Aphrodite.

400 BCE

• **396** A Spartan princess, Cynisca, is the first woman to win at the Olympic Games, in the four-horse chariot race; previously, women were not allowed to attend the Games.

• **c. 350** Praxiteles' Aphrodite of Knidos is the first life-size female nude sculpture.

• **330** A *hetaira* (companion) named Thai's allegedly persuades Alexander the Great to burn down the Persian palace of Persepolis on his campaign in Asia Minor.

◀ **THESMOPHORIA** BY FRANCIS DAVIS MILLET (1897) ROMANTICIZED THE FESTIVAL AND INCORRECTLY DEPICTED MEN TAKING PART.

